

SWINGS OF LIFE

The cool breeze hit my face as I stepped out, refreshing my mind and body. Birds flew out of their warm nests into the sky and filled my heart with lovely notes. The clear sky gave me serenity, a feeling that I desired. The dark oak tree stood still on the pavement along its diverse shades of spring, decorating the pathway. Young trees on the sides looked fresh with new leaves and flowers.

The foliage above could be my infinite dreams of scarlet and gold, playful in the soft light, ignition of colours for all who cared to see. They were the candles of the daylight and brought their art to our world with their branches taking root in the sky.

As nature was nurturing my mind, body and soul, the little voices laughing in rhyme and the cadence of children from the neighbourhood of the park brightened my mood. There was bustle and activity everywhere in the park. People engaged in different forms of recreation- brisk walkers and joggers along the pathways, some seated on the grass with cheerful conversations and grannies sat on the benches talking about those good old days.

Nature clothed itself in the beauty of its own. Into the floral vibe of the spring, my daydreams spread new tentative wings. Creativity loves to play in any season, whatever the weather, yet spring has arrived. What a feast of colour there was! Colourful variegated flowers were in full bloom on a backdrop of dark, tall pines. It was the touch of the finest artist.

I sat on an empty bench beneath a tree while admiring the park. A light breeze rustled the leaves above, creating a dance of sunlight and shade across the grass. Birds were sharing news perched on the telephone wire. Tiny feet scurried over as children wandered down a garden path. Sneakers screeched; the ball rebounded and a score was followed by cheers and rattles. The rhythmic squeaking of the swings, monkey bars, slides, see-saw, and climbers occupied with tireless children. Children laughed and ran as the sun beat down on them.

Out of touch with reality, the sight of the playground was inspiring. The little laughter brought the playground colours to an evermore heartwarming hue. Happy memories unfolded like the pages of a childhood storybook. How long has it been? Ten, maybe even fifteen years since I had last been. Memories of the past rushed to my senses as I closed my eyes gently. At the same place, at the same time, I was nostalgic for the unconditional love and fun of my family.

My father had walked fast upon the spacious pavement, hooking his arms around my feet while I clasped my arms over his broad shoulders. We called it a piggyback ride. He'd get giddy so would I.

We reached the colourful yet noisy playground. On the back, my small eyes scanned the field and looked out for the choices to play. The screams of happiness from kids filled the play area

with joy, like me spending a fulfilling day on attractive slides, merry-go-rounds and more. My eyes spotted an empty swing. My excitement knew no bounds.

I felt the touch with the warmth of the metal chains of the swing in my hands. Settled down, I looked around at the ecstatic playground, the smell of spring nipping at my nose.

"Daddy! " a loud, high-pitched voice yelled out of me, "push me forward until I feel dizzy!"

I played and played, tightly holding onto the chains. I was flying. At the top, I would feel the freedom of the newly lit day. I was as light as a bird and thought I could reach the sky and touch the sun endlessly. Flinging the sandals from the top of the swing was also fun. Soon I had learnt to push myself from the ground to increase my speed. Riding the swing standing carried me to the next level of excitement.

The joy was immeasurable to my dirty feet or messy hair. My excitement would fade when my father called out to go home or when I had finished my turn. Just as deep as the sunshine and the cherry smiles, my father brought forth different emotions from my mother.

With a cheerful smile, I opened my eyes. I took a deep breath as I watched the wind push an empty swing forward, inviting me to come and take a seat. As I walked towards the swinging chair, I felt the wood chips from underneath my feet crunch and crinkle. I sat down, feeling the hot plastic seep through my dress. My eyes closed, trying to envision that day one last time.

It was a happy and divine déjà vu, tingling my synapses and resetting my mood for the new days ahead. The value of the moment is never known until it becomes a memory.